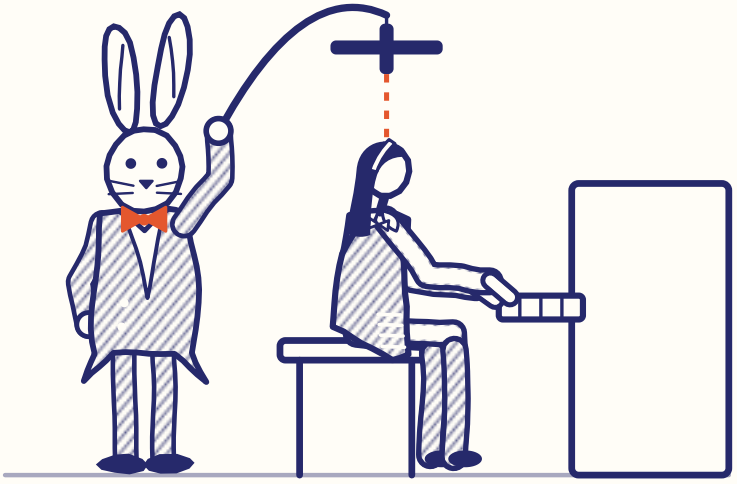
CHAPTER 1

Posture and hand shape

First, learn to sit and hold your hands. Then every note is easier.



Sit tall, like a puppet on a string.

GUESS FIRST Which finger is number 1?

answer on page 5

In this chapter

1 Sit at the piano 2
2 Let the arm carry the hand 3
3 A round hand 4
4 Finger numbers 5
5 Play: finger walks 6
6 My five checks 7

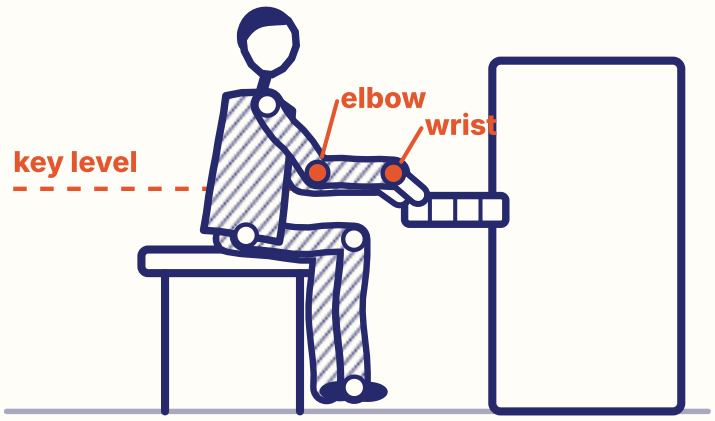
After this chapter, I can

- ☐ sit at the right height and distance
- ☐ move your hand with the whole arm
- ☐ make a round hand and play on the tips
- ☐ say every finger number, on both hands

STEP 1 OF 6

Sit at the piano

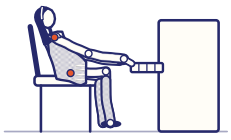
Set two things: **how high** and **how far**. Forearm level with the keys, elbows just in front of you.



At the piano

1. Sit on the **front half** of the stool, feet flat on the floor, leaning a little toward the piano. ○
2. Raise or lower the stool until your **forearm is level** with the keys. ○
3. Slide in or out until your **elbows are just in front of you**, a fist from your sides. ○

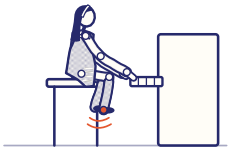
Not like this



× Leaning back, like on a sofa



× So close the elbows squash in



× Too high: feet swinging

5 IN A ROW Ready in 5 seconds: front half of the stool, feet flat, sitting tall. Someone counts. ○ ○ ○ ○ ○



THE BUTLER'S NOTE

Front half of the stool, feet flat, sit tall, leaning a little forward.

STEP 2 OF 6

Let the arm carry the hand

The fingertips stay connected to the piano. The **whole arm** leads the hand and fingers from above. Six moves, **in this order**, big body parts to small. Each one sets up the next.

1 Rag doll



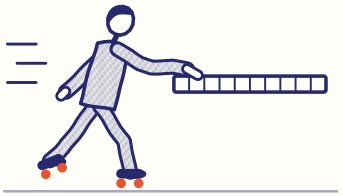
Flop forward, arms hanging heavy. Shake them loose. Float the hands up onto the keys.

2 Elbow wings



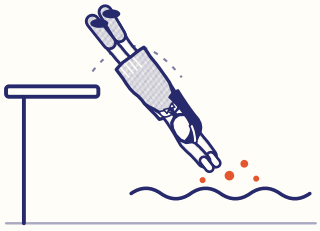
Elbows free, not stuck to your body. Float them out like wings, then back. Stop a fist from your body.

3 Arm glide



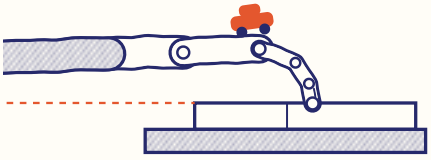
Skate the whole arm along the keys. The round hand rides to the next group of keys. The fingers ride, they don't walk.

4 Arm drop



Lift the whole arm and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm tip, soft wrist, a round sound.

5 Knuckle bridge



Your knuckles are a bridge a little car can drive over. Press one key slowly and hold for 3: the bridge stays up.

6 Wrist balloon



The wrist never sinks: as the key goes down, a balloon lifts it back up to level. The fingertip stays on the key.

5 IN A ROW All six movements in order, without looking at the book. ○ ○ ○ ○ ○



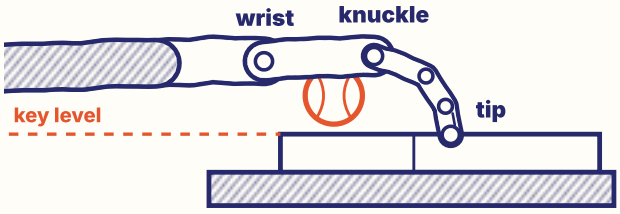
THE BUTLER'S NOTE

The arm leads from above, elbows free. It stays free, even while a finger presses.

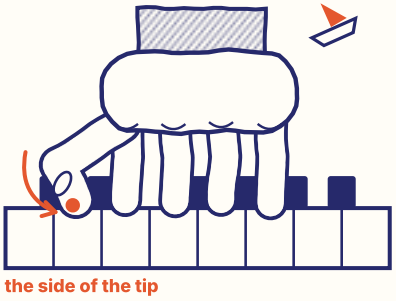
STEP 3 OF 6

A round hand

Let your arms hang, then lift your hands as if holding a small ball. Keep that shape on the keys. **Knuckles up** like a bridge. Play on the **fingertips**. Keep the wrist free: with the tip on the key, the hand sways up and down and side to side, as if a roller sat under the forearm.



Round, like holding a ball

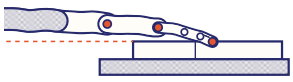


The thumb plays on the side of its tip, like a tipped boat

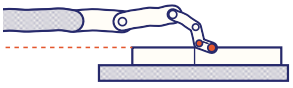
At the piano

1. Hands on your knees. Hold an imaginary ball. ○
2. Move the ball shape onto the keys without squashing it. ○
3. Play one key with each finger, on the tip. Knuckles stay up. The other fingers rest on their keys for balance. ○
4. Fingertip on a key: sway the wrist up and down, then side to side, as if on a roller. ○
5. Thumb in and out: slide the thumb in under fingers 2, 3 and 4, then back out. The hand stays round and still. ○

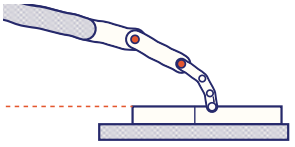
Not like this



× Flat fingers



× Tip joint caving in



× Wrist stiff and high

5 IN A ROW One key with each finger, on the tip, knuckles up: not one knuckle caves in. ○ ○ ○ ○ ○



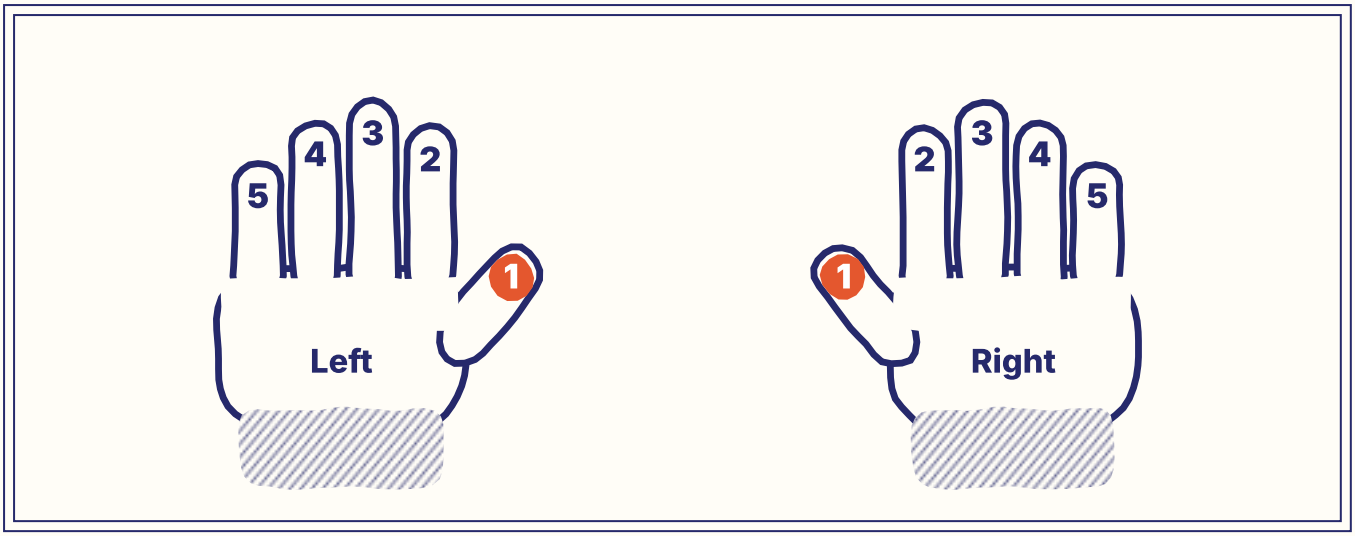
THE BUTLER'S NOTE

A free wrist, as if on a roller. Watch the knuckles and fingertips.

STEP 4 OF 6

Finger numbers

Fingers are numbered **1 to 5, from the thumb**. Same on both hands: thumbs are 1, little fingers are 5. (Page 1's answer: the thumb.)



1 Captain Thumb · 2 Pointer · 3 Tall Middle · 4 Shy Ring · 5 Baby Pinky

The mirror game

1. Hold both hands up. Wiggle each finger as you say its number. ○
2. Someone calls **"Right hand, 3!"** and you wiggle it. Try ten calls. ○
3. Swap: you call the finger, and they wiggle it. ○



BEAT YOUR TIME Number race: someone calls "Left hand, 4!" and you wiggle it. How fast can you answer ten calls? ___ s ___ s ___ s



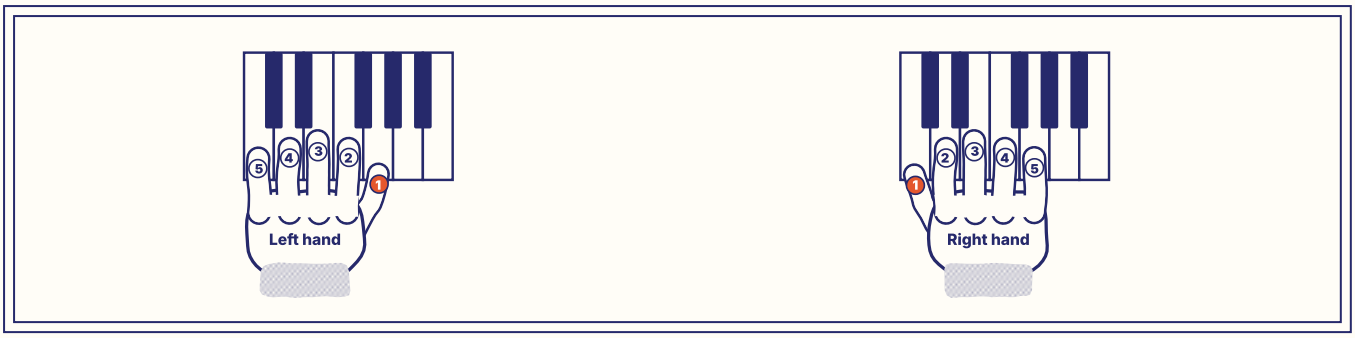
THE BUTLER'S NOTE

Fingers are numbered 1 to 5 from the thumb, on both hands.

STEP 5 OF 6 · PLAY

Finger walks

Sit well, make a round hand, and play. Start small: one note, then two, three, four, five. Key to key, the hand draws **a little rainbow**. Relaxed, never squeezed: the whole hand helps. One circle is one steady beat.





Hop on 3
one note: an arm drop on every 3

3 ○ 3 ○ 3 3 3 ○



Neighbours
two notes, next door, taking turns

2 3 2 ○ 3 2 3 ○



Up and back
three notes: up, then back down

1 2 3 ○ 3 2 1 ○



Little hill
four notes: up the hill and down

1 2 3 4 3 2 1 ○



Stairs and slide
all five: up the stairs, then down the slide

1 2 3 4 5 5 4 3 2 1

An empty dashed circle: hold the note one more beat.

5 IN A ROW 1 2 3 4 5 and back: a little rainbow over every key, shoulders soft. ○ ○ ○ ○ ○



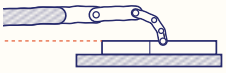
THE BUTLER'S NOTE

A little rainbow from key to key. Relaxed: the whole hand helps.

STEP 6 OF 6 · CHECK-UP

My five checks

Every time, before you play, tick each one: not yet, nearly, or got it! The check-up on paper is in the Workbook.

	NOT YET	NEARLY	GOT IT!
 Front half of the stool	○	○	★
 Feet flat, leaning a little toward the piano	○	○	★
 Sit tall, like a puppet on a string	○	○	★
 Forearm level with the keys, elbows away from your body	○	○	★
 Round hand, play on the tips	○	○	★

Colour a circle each time it gets better: not yet, then nearly, then got it!



THE BUTLER'S NOTE

All five? Then this room is yours. On to the next one.